the third at Siliguri. The idea was to not only cater for a Chinese offensive but also to deal with a threat to the narrow Siliguri Corridor that might develop from East Pakistan. As a first step, in late 1959, the Army headquartered one of the brigades of 4 Division at Gangtok, with its forward elements deployed up to Nathu La.[54]

As for NEFA, in its January 1960 Operational Instruction to Eastern Command, Army Headquarters estimated the strength of Chinese forces in the sector at one division, with another division located opposite Sikkim–Bhutan. Based on this assessment, it moved 4 Infantry Division from Punjab to NEFA and later raised XXXIII Corps with responsibility for Sikkim–Bhutan, NEFA, Assam–East Pakistan, and Nagaland. XXXIII Corps had two divisions and two brigades under its command, with one division fully devoted to combating insurgency in Nagaland. Its task was to establish a three-tiered defence, as had been visualised by Lt. Gen. S. P. P. Thorat, consisting of border outposts that controlled entry routes, vulnerable points that both supported and served as a fallback for these outposts, and a defence line resting on strong bases. While an exercise conducted in April 1960 indicated the need for another brigade in NEFA, not only was it not allotted, but instead a brigade was moved from NEFA to Nagaland in February 1961. Subsequently, in the first half of 1961, a Border Defence Study Group led by Lt. Gen. S. P. Sen projected a requirement of an additional division for NEFA, which, again, went unaddressed. This, despite a new assessment that the Chinese strength opposite NEFA had increased to three divisions. Neither Army Headquarters nor Eastern Command took cognisance of this development and continued to base their plans and deployments on the previous estimate. As a result, while the Army had an elaborate plan for the defence of NEFA, its presence on the ground was rather thin, especially along the third and vital tier of the defence line, with only two